do it. Why could they not get the [Afghan] Taliban to do it? If, as people in India say, that the [Afghan] Taliban is just a Pakistani agent, well, they are not.'[60]

By 2015, such organisational distinctions between different Afghan Taliban outfits among Indian policymakers became even more pronounced. On 3 August 2013 for instance, three suicide attackers targeted the Indian consulate in Jalalabad killing nine Afghan civilians (including eight children) and wounding twenty-four (none of whom were Indians).[61] The Afghan Taliban immediately denied any involvement in the attack while Indian security agencies blamed the LeT. 2014 was the worst of all for India in Afghanistan. Narendra Modi, a Hindu-nationalist from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the ideological parent organisation of the BJP, became India's PM with a resounding parliamentary majority. Afghanistan itself was undergoing a critical transition and national elections were underway to elect Karzai's successor. In this context, just before Modi's swearing-in ceremony, on 24 May at 3.15 AM, four LeT militants heavily armed with machine guns and rocket-propelled grenades attacked the Indian consulate in Herat. It took ten hours for the ITBP soldiers and the Afghan Special Forces to neutralise the attack. Unlike previous cases where the LeT used Afghans (with the Haqqani network's support) to target Indian installations, LeT operatives from Pakistan executed this attack.[62] It was a clear signal to the Modi government on what to expect in the coming months in its engagement with Pakistan. The CIA had given four specific prior warnings to Indian and Afghan agencies, while the fifth warning came two hours after the attack commenced.[63] Within a month, the US State Department publicly acknowledged that there was 'credible evidence' that the LeT was responsible for the consulate attack.[64]

Nearly 100 LeT militants had infiltrated into Nuristan in 2014 and were trying to setup bases in the Kamdish district.[65] When met with resistance they killed eleven Afghan Taliban militants. All that were killed had refused to disrupt the ongoing national elections.[66] Occurring in the wake of an unstable National Unity Government (NUG) in Kabul under Ghani's presidency (and Abdullah as the Chief Executive), and the changing nature of the US military involvement, an inflow of battle-hardened LeT militants on Afghan soil deeply troubled the Indian and Afghan leadership. In a confidential briefing in June 2014 to the new